

## The Game Architects

Developing a game calls for a whole lot of effort and time from several people. These are the experts who make a game possible.

Here's a look at what it takes to be one of them.

**Artist/Animator:** The people who make all those breath-taking environs and animations in a game. You need creativity and good drawing skills and familiarity with various 2D- and 3D-rendering software.

**Designer:** The folks who give the game its groove with the skills of an artis and a basic knowledge of programming fundamentals.

**Programmer:** The people who make the games tick. You need to be self-directed, have excellent knowledge of mathematics, trigonometry and physics, in addition to excellent programming skills.

**Producer:** The head honcho, he takes care of the organisation part. Producers are usually programmers or lead artists or have moved up the ranks from quality assurance.

**Game tester:** They run a game through its paces by rigorous testing. Long attention span, ability to communicate efficiently, and good memory are a must.

**Music composer/sound engineer:** The magicians behind the stunning theme music and sound effects. The music composer writes music keeping the character and situation in mind and should be a professional.

**Concept writer:** Every game has its own story, which is crafted by the concept writer. To be one, you need to have good communication skills, and understanding of how games work.

to get a foothold in the industry. To get into the arena you must have at least a year of experience to grasp the graphics and programming requirements. The entry-level requirements for a fresher are much higher than in most other programming professions. And it takes a lot of hard work.

The gaming industry is a dog-eat-dog world, especially in India where it is still in a fledgling state. So if you have any illusions of having a pleasant time with a 9 to 5 schedule where all you do is play games, now's the time to drop out! The real picture includes some 50-hour or more working weeks, very tight deadlines, and even tighter competition. The game development cycle can take months, sometimes even years as in the case of complex 3D games such as *Quake III*.

Well, so much for the hair-raising part. Now for the good news. The gaming industry provides, in most cases, flexible working hours, informal working conditions and good pay. If that's not enough, the thrill of seeing your game gaining popularity in the market is the ultimate ecstasy that any gaming geek can ever wish for!

### The starting blocks

The most essential requirement for any aspiring entrant into the world of game development is a burning passion and love for games. You need to have an in-depth knowledge of how games work, which can be attained only through playing games. Critical appreciation and insights into the game through close observation are the key here. How does the game operate? What makes it appealing? What are the goals—the different win-and-lose situations?

For instance, consider a game such as *Quake*. Here the focus is on being constantly alert and on the move, gaining attributes such as health, weapons, etc. Observing the manner in which your opponent behaves gives you an idea of how artificial intelligence (AI) is used in the game. Look at the graphics employed in the game—how is the visual effect going to enhance the experience? How does the game respond to the entire chemistry (or rather Physics) of inputs from the mouse, keyboard, joystick, etc?

Check out the graphics, the animation being used, how the background music improves the feel of the gameplay. Think about how you would improve the game if you got the chance. Try to understand the experience that the developers tried to incorporate into the game.

But be warned—dropping out of school to

study gaming on a full-time basis is not an option that you would want to consider. The game industry does not exactly encourage dropouts. A BE or a BTech in Computer Science would go a long way in helping you land that first job, especially in programming. Make sure that you have a sound educational background that is relevant to the area of the gaming industry that you want to enter.

### By design

If the labyrinths and arenas that make *Unreal Tournament* such an out-of-the-world sight and the cool graphics is what blows your mind, and you are simply itching to put your own vision into effect, then design is where you should be headed.

Though the term 'designer' is widely used, there is no such thing as a game designer. The term is loosely used to define a whole lot of jobs



**Programming games is not like standard programming. A game programmer requires more logic, even a lot of creativity"**

**Nitesh Wadekar**

Project Manager, Indiagames.com

related to designing games, such as lead designer, concept artist, level designer, texture artist, skin artist, modeller, animator, and computer game cinematic animator.

You need some basic things in your satchel before you set off on the path to becoming a game designer. First of all, get well acquainted with design software such as Director, 3D Studio Max, Maya, Photoshop, Flash, Illustrator, Lightwave, etc.

Director is very useful if you want to design 2D and 3D games (with Director 8.5), and comes with the Lingo scripting. Almost all 3D games such as *Quake*, *Doom*, etc have 3D models that usually make use of software packages such as 3D Studio Max and Maya. Illustrator proves handy when it comes to character animation. There are a whole host of free software tools that you can download from the Net and work on towards level designing. This is the best way to learn how to build your own game as well as learn the ropes.

Although you don't really need a degree in fine arts to make the grade as a designer, it is imperative that you have good drawing skills since designers are often required to make concept sketches.

It doesn't end there. A good understanding of Physics (how else are you going to animate

